Joseph O'Brien

Curriculum Vitae

Department of Philosophy
University of California, San Diego
Ridge Walk Academic Complex, Bldg. 1
Arts & Humanities, Room 0436

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Personal Website
Citizenship: United States
Last updated: October 2026

Areas of Research

AOS: Philosophy of Science, Epistemology (Social/Formal), Philosophy of AI/AI Ethics
AOC: Logic, Metaphysics of Science, Philosophy of Perception

Education

University of California, San Diego — La Jolla, CA
Ph.D., Philosophy — 2023 – present

William & Mary — Williamsburg, VA
B.S., Philosophy and Data Science (Algorithms Concentration) — 2019 – 2023

- Thesis: "Seeing What We Can't: Evaluating Implicit Biases in Deep Learning Satellite Imagery Models Trained for Poverty Prediction"

Publications

[3] Fazelpour, Sina, Joseph O'Brien, and Hannah Rubin. "Navigating Epistemic Monocultures in AI-Driven Science: A Simulation Study." *Philosophy of Science* (2026): 1–24.

[2] O'Brien, Joseph, Joseph Masotti, and Nancy Cartwright. "A Philosophical Introduction to In-Silico Clinical Trials." *European Journal for Philosophy of Science* 16, no. 3 (2026): 52.

[1] Runfola, Dan, Anthony Stefanidis, Zhonghui Lv, Joseph O'Brien, and Heather Baier. "A Multi-Glimpse Deep Learning Architecture to Estimate Socioeconomic Census Metrics in the Context of Extreme Scope Variance." *International Journal of Geographical Information Science* 38, no. 4 (2024): 726–750.

Conference Proceedings

O'Brien, Joseph D., Hannah Rubin, Kekoa Wong, and Sina Fazelpour. "Epistemic Monocultures and the Effect of AI Personalization." In *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, vol. 47, 2025.

Selected Talks

"Accommodation and Generalization in Modern Machine Learning"

- 2026 Philosophy of Science Association Biennial Meeting, Poster Session — November 2026

"When the Levee Breaks: Data Leakage and Benchmark Contamination"

- Yale Digital Ethics Center Symposium, New Haven, CT — October 2026

"Artificial Evidence: The Epistemic Status of Synthetic Data"

- Philosophy of AI Network Talks, Toronto, ON — September 2026
- Philosophy and Biology Shop Talks, Greensboro, NC — June 2026
- Georgetown–Penn Digital Ethics Workshop, Philadelphia, PA — April 2026

"From Silo to Safari: Letting Academic Inquiry Roam Free"

- UCI–UCR Graduate Conference in Philosophy — October 2025

"Epistemic Monocultures and the Effect of AI Personalization"

- CogSci 2025: Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society — August 2025
- UCI Workshop on Self-Assembling Games — January 2025

"The Signal-Noise Distinction in Statistical Modeling"

- 2024 Philosophy of Science Association Biennial Meeting, Poster Session — November 2024
- Philosophy of Statistics Early Career Summer Workshop, Univ. of Minnesota — August 2024

"The Aspirations and Shortfalls of Machine Learning Interpretability"

- EASST-4S 2024 Amsterdam: Making and Doing Transformations — July 2024

Teaching Experience

Primary Instructor

PHIL 51: Climate Ethics (UCSD) — Summer 2026

Teaching Assistant

PHIL 14: Introduction to the Nature of Reality (UCSD) — Fall 2024
PHIL 120: Symbolic Logic (UCSD) — Fall 2024
PHIL 10: Introduction to Logic (UCSD) — Winter 2025
PHIL 174: Data Ethics (UCSD) — Spring 2025
PHIL 28: Ethics in Society II (UCSD) — Summer 2025
Culture, Art, and Technology Writing Program (UCSD) — AY 2025–26, AY 2026–27

Service

Session Chair, Philosophy of Science Association Biennial Meeting — Nov. 2026
Organizer, UCSD Philosophy Graduate Conference (gradCon) — Nov. 2025 – May 2026
Graduate Representative, UCSD Philosophy Department — Aug. 2024 – June 2026
Assistant Director, Philosophy In the City, San Diego Chapter — Aug. 2024 – June 2026

- Offers in-school instructional programs for high school students

Volunteer and Instructor, Philosophy In the City — Jan. 2024 – present
Organizer, Perception Reading Group, UCSD — Aug. 2024 – 2026

Reviewer

- Philosophy of Science

Fellowships and Awards

Yale Digital Ethics Center Symposium Best Paper Award — 2026

First-Year Fellowship, University of California, San Diego *($30,000)* 2023–2024
Computational Geography Fellowship Award, Commonwealth Cyber Initiative *($500)* 2023
Honors Fellowship, Charles Center, William & Mary *($4,000)* 2022